BATTLING THE ODDS

THE ELECTORAL CONTESTS OF NOVEMBER WILL DECIDE THE FATE OF SEVERAL POLITICAL VETERANS AND ALSO DETERMINE THE TONE IF NOT THE OUTCOME OF THE GENERAL ELECTION IN 2024

By **KAUSHIK DEKA**

Come November, and 161 million voters in five states—Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Telangana and Mizoram—will exercise their franchise to elect their governments. Elections in these five states, which account for 83 of the 543 Lok Sabha seats, are the last major battles before the general election in 2024. Of course, state elections do not necessarily influence, or presage, the outcome of the subsequent Lok Sabha election—in the 2018 assembly polls, for example, the Congress notched up victories in Rajasthan, MP and Chhattisgarh, but won just three of the 65 Lok Sabha seats in these states in 2019.

Yet, the results of the electoral contests in November will most certainly set the tone and narrative of the poll campaigns of political parties, particularly the two national ones—the Bharatiya Janata Party and Congress. Even in 2018, following its defeat in three states, the BJP-led Union government made several course corrections, including launching populist schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi. These poll battles will also determine the political future of several veterans, including the incumbent MP chief minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan of the BJP, his Rajasthan counterpart Ashok Gehlot of the Congress, as well as former CMs, be it Kamal Nath of the Congress in MP, or the BJP's Vasundhara Raje in Rajasthan or Raman Singh in Chhattisgarh.

These will also be the first big elections after 26 Opposition parties, including the Congress, came together to form the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance or INDIA. Ironically, the INDIA experiment will not be at play in any of the five states. In Rajasthan, MP and Chhattisgarh, the Congress and BJP, which leads the National Democratic Alliance, are engaged in a direct contest. In Telangana, the K. Chandrashekar Rao-led Bharat Rashtra Samithi is part of neither NDA nor INDIA. In Mizoram, the ruling MNF (Mizo National Front) is part of the NDA at the Centre but has no partnership with the BJP in the state.

In the latter two states, the incumbents—KCR in Telangana and Chief Minister Zoramthanga in Mizoram—are facing three-cornered contests, the former pitted against the Congress and BJP, and the latter against the ZPM (Zoram People's Movement) and the Congress. A win will put KCR in a better position in any possible electoral arrangement with either national alliance for the Lok Sabha polls. While the Congress is seeking a revival of fortunes in Telangana and Mizoram, the BJP's challenge is much tougher in electoral landscapes that are organically different from its ideological standpoint.

Barring Mizoram, these elections will also be the first test of what is already one of INDIA's chief poll planks—the demand for